

When Is a Crime Reported?

Crime data often includes two important dates: when an incident occurred and when it was reported. This project looks at the gap between those dates across more than one million Los Angeles crime records from 2020 through 2024.

The overall pattern is concentrated around short gaps. 48.0% of records have the same occurrence and report date, while another 38.9% have a gap of one to seven days. Altogether, 86.9% of records have an occurrence-to-report gap of seven days or less.

The pattern changes substantially across crime types. Among categories with at least 2,000 records, 53.5% of embezzlement records had gaps greater than 30 days, compared with 28.2% of identity-theft records. In contrast, only 0.7% of robbery records and 1.3% of battery-simple-assault records had gaps greater than 30 days.

There is also a smaller long tail in the data. 0.75% of all records had gaps exceeding one year. Some crime categories had noticeably higher shares, including 6.0% of rape records and 5.3% of identity-theft records.

These patterns show that the timing recorded in crime data is not consistent across all types of incidents. Most records have short gaps, but certain categories appear much more often in the longer tail.

There is an important limitation to this analysis. An occurrence-to-report gap is simply the difference between two dates recorded in the dataset. It should not automatically be interpreted as how long a victim waited to report an incident. The dataset also reflects historical reporting, transcription, and record-keeping practices. The results therefore describe patterns in the available records rather than explaining why individual incidents were reported when they were.